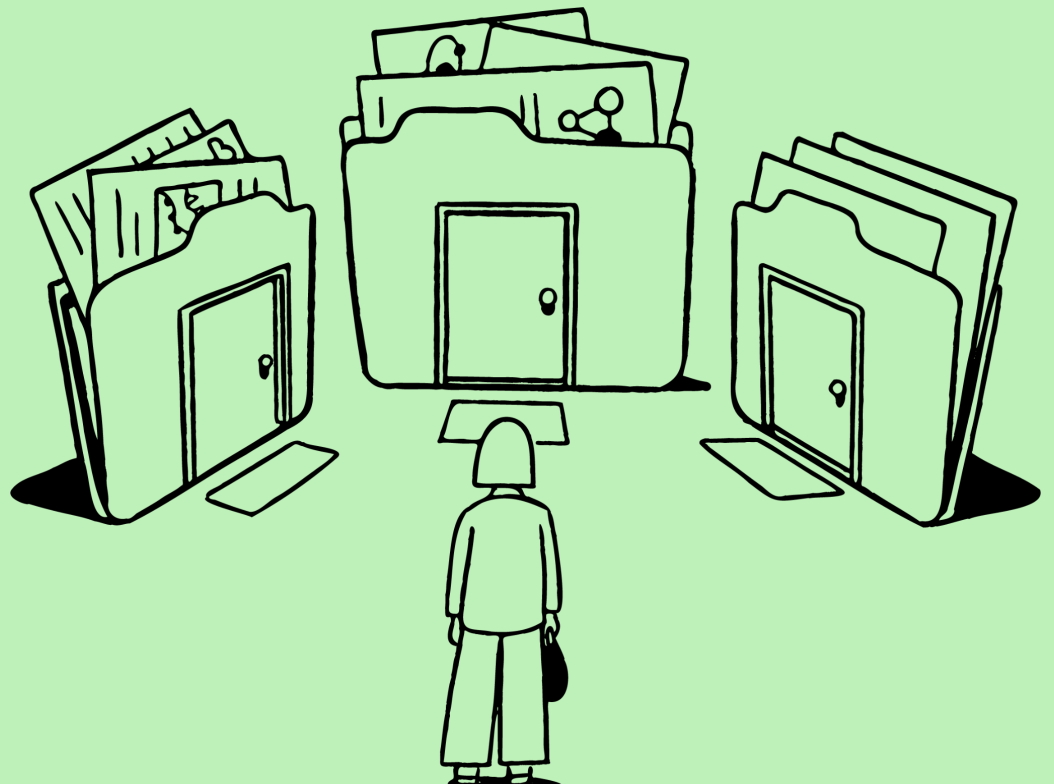


Brand voice, messaging and style toolkit

Version 2.0



Contents

[A reminder of our mission](#)

[Brand voice \(how we communicate\)](#)

[Messaging toolkit](#)

[Talking about who we are](#)

[Talking about our resources](#)

[Talking about our curriculum plans](#)

[Talking about our AI tools](#)

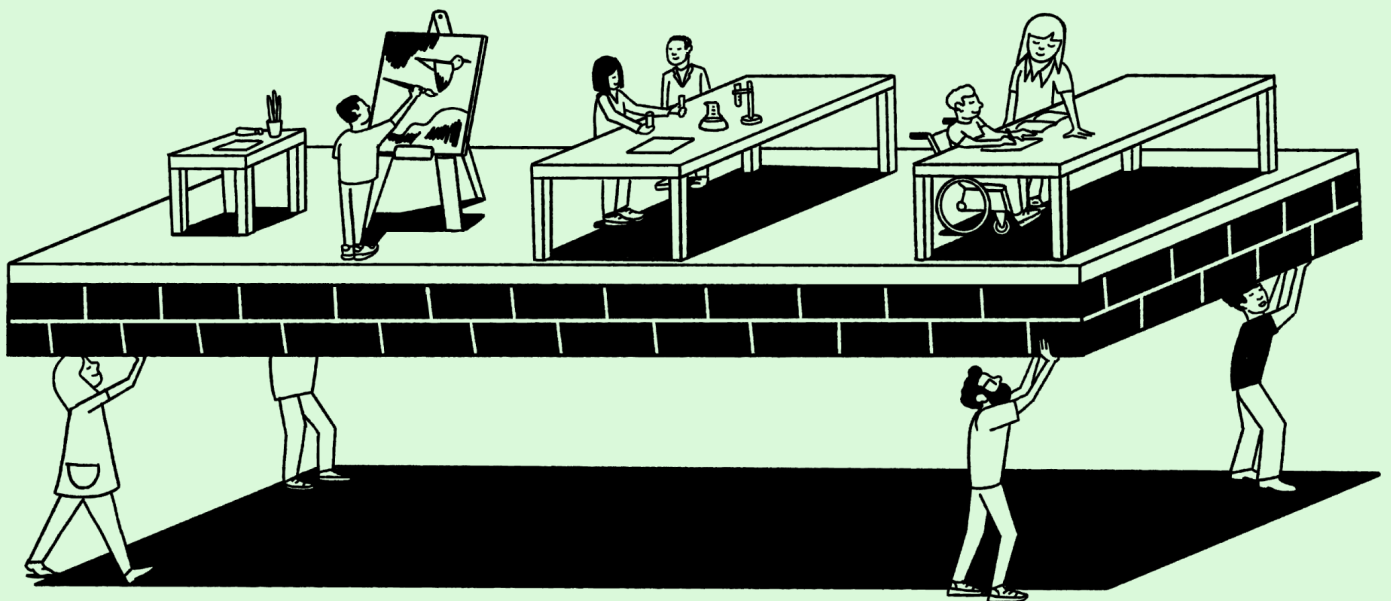
[Talking about pupils using Oak](#)

[Style guide: A-Z](#)

(covers styling of grammar and common phrases)

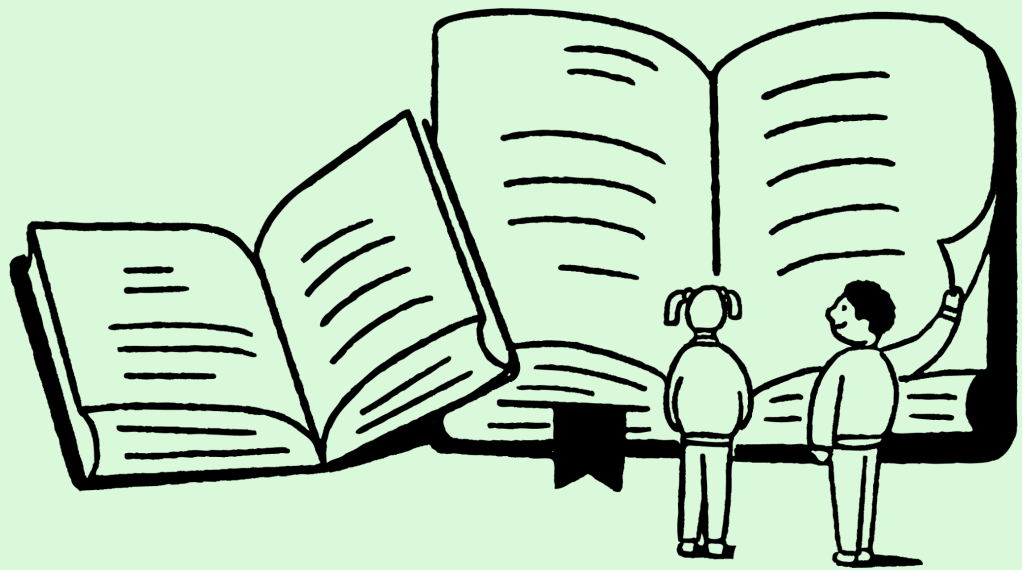
Our mission

To improve pupil outcomes and close the disadvantage gap by supporting teachers to teach, and pupils to access, a high-quality curriculum.



Brand voice

The principles we follow in our communication and guidance on how to apply Oak's tone.



How we communicate with our audience

Our aim is to be a respected, relevant and trusted national resource for the country's teachers. Everything we say, and the way in which we say it, reflects this.

We follow **three key principles** when representing Oak in writing and presentation:

1. We empower teachers.

We exist for teachers and pupils, and everything we do is to support them. We're humble and focus not on what we're doing, but on how we can help teachers and learners. We're supportive, inclusive, never judgemental.

Quick tips on how to apply this in communication:

- **Remember, we exist for teachers.** We do great stuff, but all of it is for them. Pivot your content to celebrate them – not us and our achievements.
- **Make it about them.** Reread what you've written. How many 'we's and 'our's can you change to 'you' and 'your's'?
- **Meet them on their level.** We're innovators, and we're inviting teachers along with us. We should be able to share knowledge and expertise as if we're having a conversation in the staffroom.

2. We're personable.

We're a professional, innovative, high-performing organisation – but we're an organisation made up of humans, and our tone is always approachable, friendly, positive, and light. We understand the demands of teaching, and we're realistic and understanding about that. We're never reserved: remember, we're here to openly impart our collective knowledge and expertise with the sector.

Quick tips on how to apply this in communication:

- **Talk in the first/second person.** You, us, we, our. Not Oak this, Oak that.
- **Write how you'd speak.** Reread what you've written. Is it something you'd say aloud in a casual staffroom conversation? That's the tone we're going for.
- **Keep it inclusive and accessible.** We're a professional, expert organisation, and we make that known by imparting our expertise; not by reserving it. We make things easy to understand – like a teacher delivering a lesson to their pupils.

3. We're clear and direct.

We use simple words, because jargon complicates conversation and limits understanding. We get straight to the point and keep sentences short and digestible. We opt for contractions e.g. *we're* instead of *we are*; and we don't over-formalise, e.g. we use *make sure* instead of *ensure*, *so* instead of *therefore*. You can always cut words. Wherever you can, do.

Quick tips on how to apply this in communication:

- **Use simple words.** Avoid jargon. Use accessible vocabulary. Always opt for contractions.
- **Get to the point.** You don't always need to set the scene with an introduction; teachers are already living in the scene. Jump in with the key message.
- **Keep it short.** You can always cut words. Where you can, do.

Talking to our non-core audience

The education sector and stakeholders

Teachers are our core audience, but we of course also work with unions, subject bodies, partners, and education leaders. We understand that we have a national responsibility and interest, and sometimes we need to speak in a formal tone. We continue to be clear, concise and straightforward.

Pupils and parents

Although we have a dedicated space for pupils, we expect these pupils to be guided by schools, teachers, or parents; so we don't differ in our tone.

We occasionally talk to parents when responding to their queries. We frame conversations around supporting their child's learning while still being led by their school and teachers. We know many parents use us for home-schooling, though we don't advocate it.

Messaging toolkit

A collection of approved messaging to help you communicate confidently and consistently about our work.



Talking about who we are

Opening statement		
We're Oak, and we want to give you back hours of your week. We do that by giving you free resources and tools to help you prepare high-quality teaching for all your pupils.		
Expanded description		
Whether you're creating new lessons, refreshing your approach, or solving a last-minute challenge, our resources give you a strong foundation that means you get there faster. Created by UK curriculum and subject experts, they're quality-assured and tested by teachers. They can support planning at every level – from curriculum design to lessons. And they include helpful materials for the classroom, such as quizzes, worksheets and slides. You absolutely know your pupils best, so just think of us as your handy starting point.		
An additional line for...		
newcomers	cherrypickers	architects
Maybe you're looking for ways to develop your practice and confidence, or perhaps you're getting to grips with a new subject. Our resources give you a strong foundation that means you get there faster.	All our resources can be adapted to your class, location or approach. And using our intuitive AI tools, you can tailor anything – or create something new – in minutes.	All of our resources are built on pedagogical evidence of what works, supporting planning at every level.

Talking about our resources

Opening statement		
Designed by experts, our resources give you a strong starting point – whether you’re creating new lessons, refreshing your approach, or solving a last-minute challenge – and they’re all completely yours to adapt.		
Expanded description		
Save hours of planning each week, with free resources that help you prepare high-quality classroom teaching for all your pupils. Created by UK curriculum and subject experts, they’re quality-assured and tested by teachers. Every lesson includes teacher-led videos to support your teaching as well as downloadable quizzes, worksheets and slides. Make them your own: grab a handful of slides, or borrow the whole deck. Add or remove scaffolding. Introduce local context. Plus, we help with keywords, common misconceptions, and share tips from expert teachers to give you a strong foundation. Browse by key stage or topic to find what you need fast. Our resources are part of wider curriculum sequences, to support your planning at every level, from curriculum design to lessons.		
An additional line for...		
newcomers	cherrypickers	architects
Our lesson resources also include valuable information to help you prepare, such as keywords, common misconceptions and tips from experienced teachers.	Search by key stage or topic to find what you need, fast. Plus you can use our intuitive AI tools to tailor our resources – or create something new – in minutes.	Feel confident in what you are using for planning with resources that are aligned to the national curriculum and part of wider curriculum sequences.

Talking about our curriculum plans

Opening statement		
All of our curriculum plans have been expert designed, quality assured, and tested by teachers across the country. It's all aligned to the national curriculum and we also cover exam boards at secondary. So you can feel confident in what you use for your planning.		
Expanded description		
Every school's approach to curriculum design is different. Whether you are starting from scratch or refreshing your existing curricula, it can be helpful to see examples to inspire your own. Our interactive curriculum plans could be just the inspiration you need for your long or short-term planning. Use our plans to explore our sequences, each developed by leading subject experts from across the country, to build your knowledge of curriculum planning; or use them as inspiration for your own planning, seeing where you could use our teaching resources to update what you've already got. Each subject is based on its own set of principles, and we've included detail on the thinking, structure and focus behind our plans, so you can feel confident that what you're using is relevant and high-quality. You can also use the curriculum plans to see what resources are coming for subjects later this academic year.		
An additional line for...		
newcomers	cherrypickers	architects
See how others tackle planning, and feel confident you're teaching the right content at the right time.	Save time searching by filtering to see only the year groups and threads that are relevant to you. You also have the option to see lessons connected by 'threads': repeated ideas that run through key stages to build learning over time.	Use our interactive curriculum plans as models and inspiration, with engaging, relevant content, when designing your own school curriculum.

Talking about our AI tools

Opening statement		
Transform your lesson prep with our AI tools - national curriculum-aligned, classroom-ready, and built to help you create, adapt, and enhance your lessons in minutes, while keeping quality high and content safe.		
Expanded description		
Our free AI tools are designed to save you time while keeping quality high. Your AI lesson assistant, Aila, helps you create and adapt lessons in minutes through a collaborative, step-by-step process. You can effortlessly personalise for reading age, add context for your pupils, and download fully editable plans. You can also enhance any lessons you already have by instantly generating glossaries, quizzes, comprehension tasks, and more, at the click of a button. You can trust in our AI. Unlike generic tools, ours are built for you - powered by our national curriculum-aligned library and expert-reviewed to give you UK classroom-ready, reliable, and safe results. Our AI tools are here to help you plan faster and smarter - not to take over your process. You stay in control, using AI to spark ideas, tailor lessons, and save time so you can focus on your pupils.		
An additional line for...		
newcomers	cherrypickers	architects
With our AI tools, you can feel confident in the classroom - creating and adapting national curriculum-aligned lessons and resources in minutes, so you spend less time worrying where to start and more time focusing on your pupils.	With our AI tools, you can create and refresh high-quality, national curriculum-aligned lessons and resources for your classroom in minutes - saving you time while keeping your teaching fresh and engaging.	With our AI tools, you can raise the quality of teaching across your team - co-creating national curriculum-aligned lessons quickly and supporting others with classroom-ready, reliable resources.

AI tool language: dos and don'ts

	Avoid	Do
Aila's role	Overstating Aila's role: Don't describe Aila as doing a teacher's work or taking over their tasks/responsibilities. Implying Aila leads lesson creation: Avoid phrases that suggest Aila is the main creator or planner of lessons. Examples to avoid: • "Aila creates your lessons." • "Aila designs lessons for teachers."	Keep teachers firmly in control: Make it clear that teachers make every decision about what to teach and how. Position Aila as empowering, not replacing: Emphasise that Aila is the teacher's planning partner, not a substitute for their expertise. Highlight customisation: That Aila provides a starting point that teachers adapt to their own teaching style, needs and pupils. Example phrases: • "You guide Aila to create the content you want and need." • "Aila provides a solid foundation to build from and tailor to the needs of your pupils."
Aila's output	Overpromising completeness: Don't say Aila "creates everything you need" or that the resources are fully finished. Implying polished, ready-to-teach materials: Avoid suggesting that images, slide decks or formatting are final as some elements may still require teacher tweaks. Example phrases to avoid: • "Aila delivers a fully finished lesson pack ready to go." • "No further changes needed."	Highlight speed and quality: Emphasise that Aila quickly produces national curriculum-aligned and UK classroom-ready, editable starting points. Show flexibility and teacher customisation: Make clear the resources can and should be adapted. Example phrasing: • "Creates quality lessons and resources in minutes." • "Customise lessons to the needs of your pupils or context." • "Download in multiple editable formats to adapt with ease."

Talking about pupils using Oak

Opening statement

All the units and lessons available to you can be sent directly to pupils to complete in their own tailored area. Set homework, revision and keep absent pupils' learning on track, without adding to your workload.

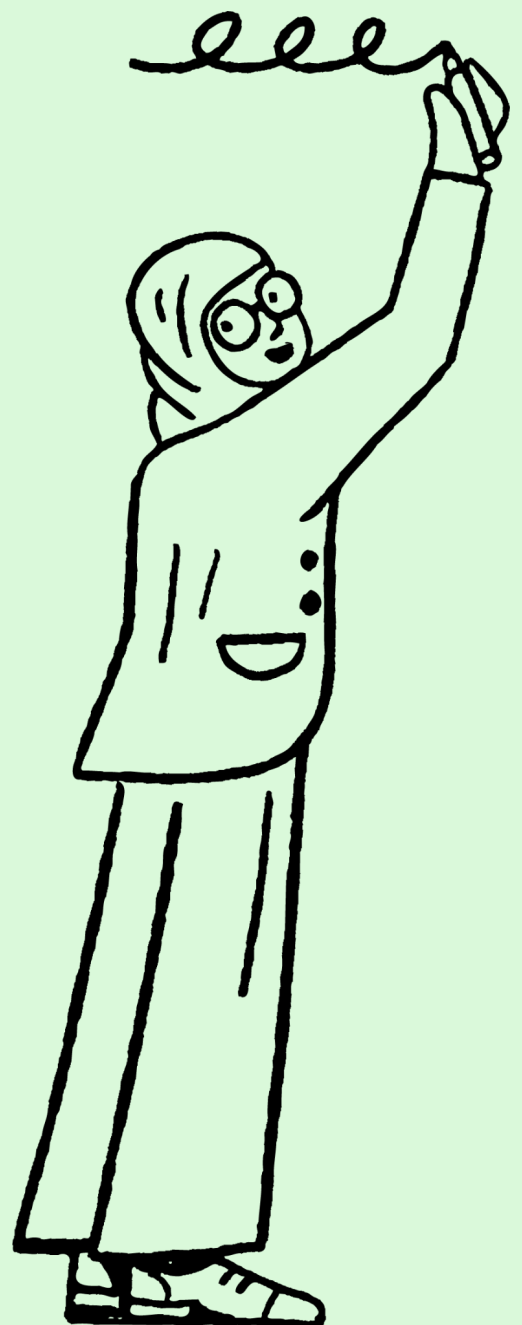
Expanded description

It only takes seconds to select and send resources such as videos, worksheets and quizzes to your pupils for them to complete.

We've designed an area on our website especially for them, having researched and tested it extensively to make sure it's easy to use, motivational, and that they can continue to learn effectively outside of school. Pupils can take a starter quiz to check prior knowledge, watch a video of the lesson being taught by a teacher, and then take an exit quiz to check what they've learnt; they'll be given real-time feedback on their answers too and can use a hint function if needed.

Then you can see their progress with our easy results-sharing function. You'll be able to see how much of the video was watched, details of quiz scores and attempts, and whether or not the worksheet was downloaded. All so you can feel confident on which areas your pupils need more support in.

Style guide



A-Z

academic year

refers to the school year; use initial year in full and then abbreviate second year followed by a forward slash: *2022/23 academic year*

AI

Acceptable to use the acronym without expanding on meaning. Always capitals.

Aila

treat as a proper noun; never *AILA*

AI lesson assistant

Aila's namesake; alternatively use *AI-powered lesson assistant* to provide more context; sentence case; never *lesson planning assistant*

Americanisms

when referring to American spellings; treat as proper noun

arm's-length body

sentence case, reduce to acronym after initial use (ALB); note that gov are inconsistent on this; we can flex but should always be consistent across a single document

board vs Board

always lower case unless it's part of a proper title: so upper case for the 'Oak's Board', but lower case for 'board meeting'

calendar year

refers to the year running January-December; style in full, e.g. *2024*; when describing range, use initial year in full and then abbreviate second year followed by a forward slash: *2022-23*

academic year

refers to the school year;

curriculum

what we use when we refer to one course of study, eg *English curriculum*; the plural is *curricula*

curriculum partners

how we refer to the schools and organisations we're working with to develop our curriculum; always lowercase

curriculum plans

Sentence case

Dates

- **in marketing material:**
 - Style as: Thursday 1st January 2025.
 - when challenged for space, remove day and abbreviate month to shorthand;

- **for Annual Report and Accounts:**
 - Style as: 1 January 2025.
- **all: year ranges**
 - Style as: 2024-25. Use initial year in full and then abbreviate final year followed by a hyphen.

Department for Education (DfE)

Use 'the' before Department for Education; but not before DfE.

Always a lowercase f in the acronym.

early career teacher

sentence case; *ECT* is a commonly-used abbreviation in the sector; replaced *newly qualified teacher*

early years (EYFS)

sentence case when used in full; opt for the acronym as this is common use in the sector

edtech

not EdTech, or Ed-Tech.

education sector

not system; we work with schools and partners from across the sector.

exit quiz

full curriculum package

A term used to describe the set of lesson planning and teaching resources we procure from curriculum partners

gaps in knowledge

we talk about addressing gaps in knowledge or understanding, instead of *catch-up*

GCSE, GCSEs

no full stops between the initials, no apostrophe in the plural

guardrails

one word

half term

no hyphen needed, unless followed by a noun; e.g. *your half-term plans*

headteacher

one word; you can use *head* if the context is clear

high quality vs high-quality

should use a hyphen when followed by a noun; *our resources are of a high quality, we offer high-quality resources*

independent public body

but if you have to use it in formal documents, use *arm's-length body*

Job titles

Treat as a proper noun when attached to a name (e.g. Bob, Headteacher), or when calling out a specific title (e.g. We are looking for an Operational Manager).
Generic titles should be treated as a normal noun. (E.g. Bob is a headteacher; let me ask my assistant).

key learning points

key stage

two words, sentence case, followed by a numeral; capitalised when abbreviated, e.g. *KS4*;
when using in body text, we use hyphens to indicate range and avoid repetition, e.g. *KS1-2*;
but can use forward slashes when using alone (e.g. labelling a list of subjects) e.g. *KS1/2*

keyword

one word

learning cycle

lesson planning and teaching resources

how we refer to what we offer teachers; can be abbreviated to *planning and teaching resources* or *teaching resources*

large language models

sentence case; shorten to *LLM* after initial use

lesson titles

should be in sentence case e.g. *Poetry about place and home*; the exception to this is when referring to texts, which should be in title case and styled in apostrophes: e.g. *Jack and the Beanstalk': reading and writing*

licence and licensing

licence is a noun. Licensing is an adjective.

E.g. *...on an open licence. ...our open-licensed resources.*

multi-academy trust

with a hyphen; always lowercase unless part of a name

national curriculum for England

should be in sentence case; commonly abbreviated to *the national curriculum*

non-departmental public body

Sentence case. Reduce to acronym (NDPB) after initial use

Oak or Oak National Academy

abbreviate our name, either following an initial use of 'Oak National Academy', or immediately if the brand name is already visible alongside the copy e.g. in a logo; generally however we should use first person (*we* and *our*), unless writing formally.

Do not use: ONA, Oak Academy, The National Academy, The Oak National Academy

Open Government Licence

treat as a proper noun; abbreviate to *OGL* after initial use

primary

sentence case, unless it's part of a school name.

prompt (AI)

treat as a common noun

pupils

instead of students or learners

retrieval-augmented generation

sentence case; shorten to RAG after initial use

SATs

no full stops between the initials, no apostrophe

school subjects

sentence case for all except languages and acronyms: *maths, French, RE, science, English*

school terms (autumn, spring, summer)

treat as common nouns; there are exceptions to this however, use sensible judgement and style with consistency

secondary

sentence case, unless it's part of a school name

sentence case vs title case in headings, titles and products

always opt for sentence case; title case is a barrier for accessibility

slide decks

instead of *presentations, powerpoints* etc; *slides* can be used informally

special educational needs / and disabilities (SEND)

sentence case, capitals for the acronym

starter quiz

or 'let's get started with a quiz' for pupils

time

use am/pm in lowercase; when on the hour, always style with a single numeral e.g. *5pm*; when past the hour, style with a colon e.g. *5:30pm*; we use hyphens to indicate time ranges, and use singular instances of am/pm: e.g. *3:30-5pm, 8am-1pm*

worksheet

not *sheet*

year groups

sentence case, two words; again sentence case when describing specific year groups, followed by a number e.g. *year 8*; unless when abbreviated (use only when space is short), e.g. *Y8*; we use hyphens to indicate ranges, e.g. *years 7-11*.